ALL HAIL KING KHAN

Riding on a stupendous year, the Badshah of Bollywood emerged on top after 12 years. Deepika remains the nation's leading lady

By SUHANI SINGH



Q. Who is the No. 1 hero in the country?

1. **SHAH RUKH KHAN** **27.6** [22.3]
2. **AMITABH BACHCHAN** **24.1** [27.3]
3. **SALMAN KHAN** **8.9** [7.9]
4. **AKSHAY KUMAR** **8.6** [8.6]
5. **ALLU ARJUN** **5.4** [5.6]

MILIND SHELTE

The king's reign is over and the Badshah returns to reclaim the throne after 12 years. Amitabh Bachchan, long an invincible force in INDIA TODAY's Mood of the Nation poll, was replaced by 2023's entertainer of the year—Shah Rukh Khan. *Pathaan*, SRK's first release in four years, became the first Hindi film to make Rs 500 crore-plus domestically. Seven months later, he beat his own record, with home production *Jawan* grossing Rs 554 crore in India alone, becoming the highest-grossing Hindi film of all time. Both films amassed Rs 1,000 crore worldwide, underlining Khan's global appeal too. But come Christmas, SRK fatigue seemed to have set in as *Dunki* failed to replicate the blockbuster success of SRK's other releases in 2023 though it still raked in a creditable Rs 200 crore. Riding on such a fabulous year, it was but natural that SRK would overtake the 81-year-old legend, but the Big B did manage second place despite not having had a noteworthy release. Allu Arjun made his top five debut, as he won the National Award for best actor for his swashbuckling turn as and in *Pushpa* (2021 release).

Deepika Padukone, SRK's leading lady in *Pathaan* and appearing also in *Jawan*,